

Building and Editing Your Own Website with AI

Overview

In this activity, you'll build a real, live website using [al-folio](#), a template built for academics and researchers, and AI as your coding assistant. You don't need to know how to code going in. You'll do everything in your browser.

This activity follows a Use → Modify → Create progression: you'll start by using the al-folio template, modify it to make it your own, and then create something new that wasn't in the template at all. Throughout, you'll use AI (GitHub Copilot) as a coding assistant.

Copilot chat (How to share): [Type here]

AI tool used in this activity: [Type here]

Chat link (Any other AI tool you used): [Type here]

Part 1: Create your GitHub account

1. Go to github.com and click Sign up.
1. Enter your email, create a password, and pick a username.
Choose username carefully, it becomes part of your website address and is hard to change later.
2. Verify your email.

Your GitHub username: [Type here]

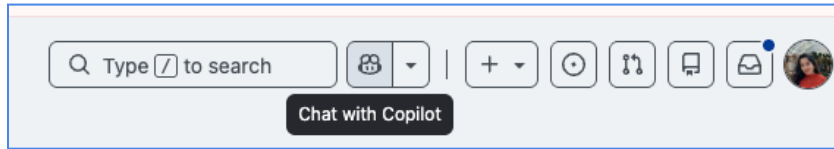
Part 2: GitHub Copilot helper

You'll create your repo in Part 3 below. Come back to this section anytime after that when you need Copilot's help.

GitHub Copilot is a built-in AI assistant. Because it can see your *repo* (short for "repository," basically the folder that holds all your website's files) and files, it can point you to exactly which file to edit for a given change, explain code, help you word things, suggest colors, and help you troubleshoot when something breaks.

1. **How to find Copilot:**

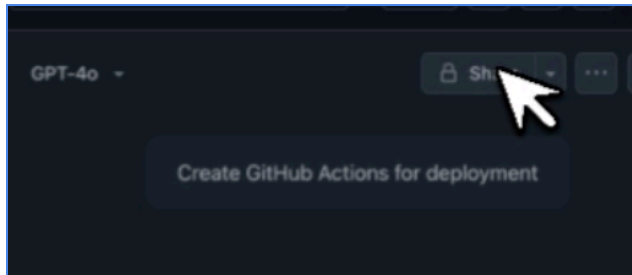
- a. Click the Copilot icon (🤖) in the top bar of any GitHub page, or go to github.com/copilot.



- b. Tell Copilot what you're trying to do (e.g., "update my bio ..."). It will look at your repo and tell you which file to change and suggest the edit.

2. How to share your Copilot conversation:

- a. **Share button** ([Share Copilot Chat conversations in public preview](#))
 - i. Click **Share** (appears after your first prompt), then click **Share** again to generate the link
 - ii. Copy the link and paste it wherever you're submitting



- b. **Export as Markdown**
 - i. In the sidebar, click the "..." menu next to your conversation
 - ii. Click **Export** → **Markdown**
 - iii. This downloads a `.md` file. Upload it to your Google Drive named `Activity4.md`

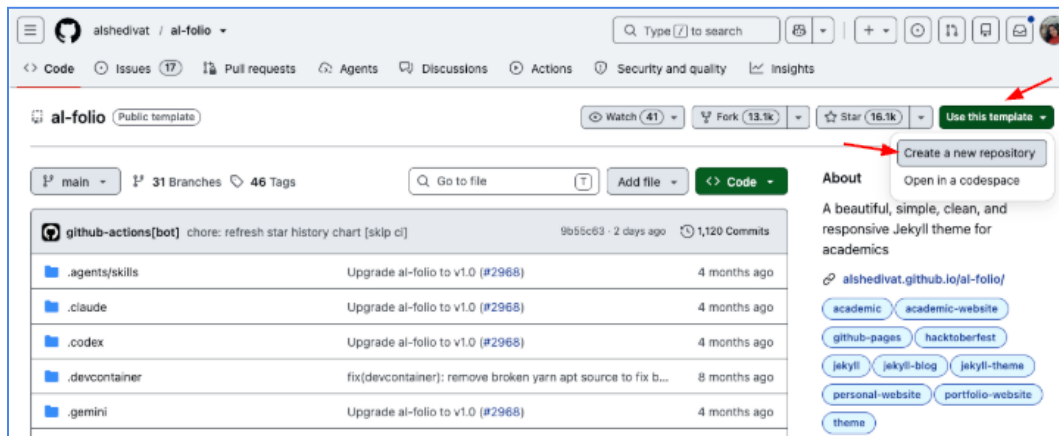


Part 3: Choose your template

This activity uses [al-folio](#), a website template built for academics and researchers. You can see what a finished site looks like at the [live demo](#) before you get started.

1. Open [al-folio](#).

- Click ["Use this template"](#) (not "Fork").



- Name your repository `yourusername.github.io`, using your actual username. This exact format matters, it's what gives you a clean web address.
- Leave "Include all branches" **unchecked**.
- Set it to `Public`, then click `Create repository`.

Create a new repository

Repositories contain a project's files and version history. Have a project elsewhere? [Import a repository](#).
Required fields are marked with an asterisk (*).

Start with a template
Templates pre-configure your repository with files.

alshedivat/al-folio

Include all branches
If enabled, all branches from the template repository will be included.

Off

1

General

Owner *

salmaelotmani

Repository name *

CS199.github.io

CS199.github.io is available.

Great repository names are short and memorable. How about [potential-octo-memory](#)?

Description

0 / 350 characters

2

Configuration

Choose visibility *
Choose who can see and commit to this repository

Public

Create repository

- Go to `Settings → Actions → General → Workflow permissions`, and select "Read and write permissions." This step is required. Al-folio builds and publishes your site automatically using GitHub Actions, and it needs this permission to work.

<> Code Issues Pull requests Agents Actions Projects Wiki Security and quality Insights **Settings**

Default workflow permissions settings saved.

General

Access

Collaborators

Moderation

Code, planning, and automation

Rulesets

Branches

Tags

Actions

General

Runners

Policies Preview

OIDC

Webhooks

Copilot

Planning

Environments

Codespaces

Pages

Actions permissions

☒ **Allow all actions and reusable workflows**
Any action or reusable workflow can be used, regardless of who authored it or where it is defined.

☐ **Disable actions**
The Actions tab is hidden and no workflows can run.

☐ **Allow salmaelotmani actions and reusable workflows**
Any action or reusable workflow defined in a repository within salmaelotmani can be used.

☐ **Allow salmaelotmani, and select non-salmaelotmani, actions and reusable workflows**
Any action or reusable workflow that matches the specified criteria, plus those defined in a repository within salmaelotmani, can be used. [Learn more about allowing specific actions and reusable workflows to run.](#)

☐ **Require actions to be pinned to a full-length commit SHA**

Save

Artifact and log retention

Choose the repository settings for artifacts and logs.

Artifact and log retention

90 days Save

There is a maximum limit of 90 days. [Learn more about the artifact and log retention policy.](#)

Scroll down

Planning

Environments

Codespaces

Pages

Security and quality

Advanced Security

Deploy keys

Secrets and variables

Integrations

GitHub Apps

Email notifications

Artifact and log retention

90 days Save

There is a maximum limit of 90 days. [Learn more about the artifact and log retention policy.](#)

Approval for running fork pull request workflows from contributors

Choose which subset of users will require approval before running workflows on their pull requests. Both the pull request author and the actor of the pull request event triggering the workflow will be checked to determine if approval is required. If approval is required, a user with write access to the repository must [approve the pull request workflow to be run](#).

☐ **Require approval for first-time contributors who are new to GitHub**
Only users who are both new on GitHub and who have never had a commit or pull request merged into this repository will require approval to run workflows.

☒ **Require approval for first-time contributors**
Only users who have never had a commit or pull request merged into this repository will require approval to run workflows.

☐ **Require approval for all external contributors**
All users that are not a member or owner of this repository will require approval to run workflows.

Save

Workflow permissions

Choose the default permissions granted to the GITHUB_TOKEN when running workflows in this repository. You can specify more granular permissions in the workflow using YAML. [Learn more about managing permissions.](#)

☒ **Read and write permissions**
Workflows have read and write permissions in the repository for all scopes.

☐ **Read repository contents and packages permissions**
Workflows have read permissions in the repository for the contents and packages scopes only.

Choose whether GitHub Actions can create pull requests or submit approving pull request reviews.

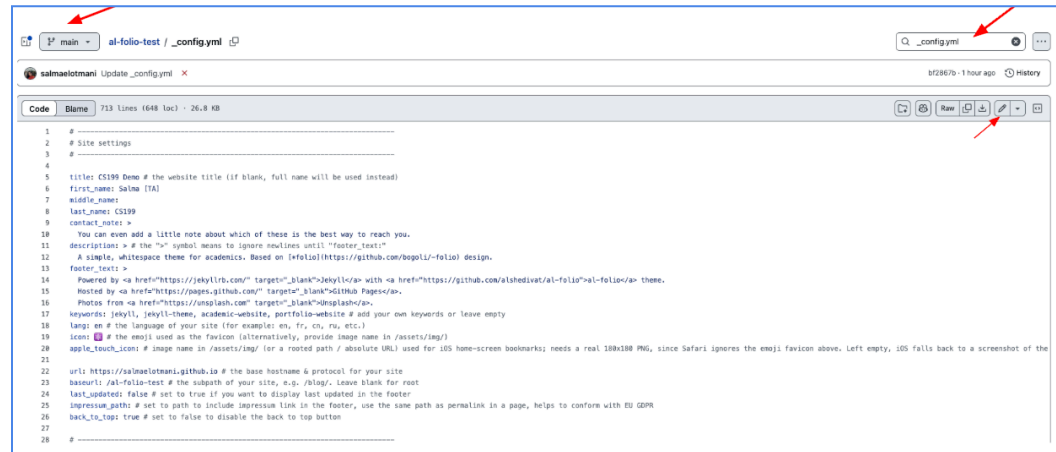
☐ **Allow GitHub Actions to create and approve pull requests**

Save

Part 4: Turn your website on

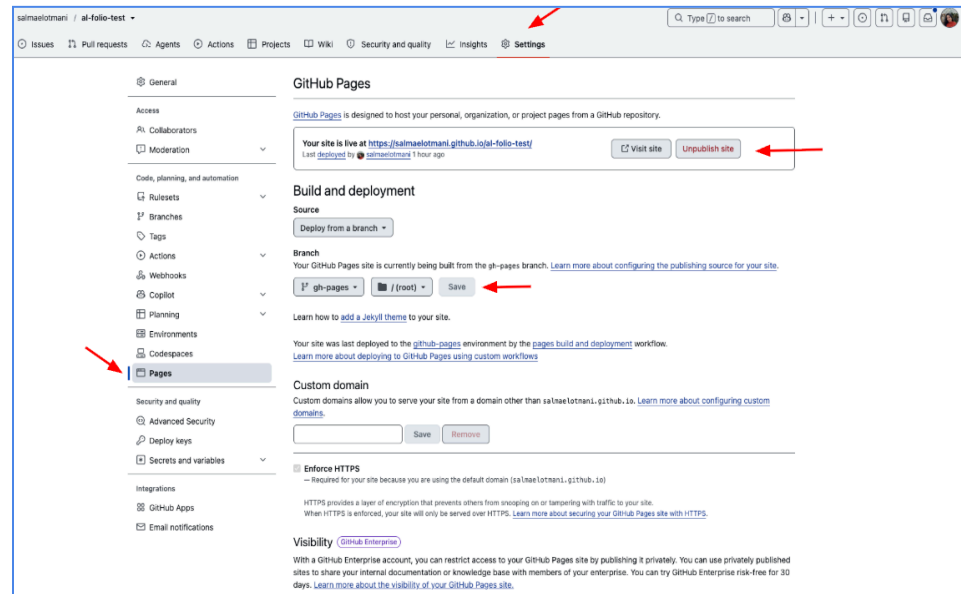
1. Open `_config.yml` in the GitHub web editor (click the pencil icon) and update:

- `title`: your site's name
- `first_name`: your first name
- `last_name`: your last name
- `url`: `https://yourusername.github.io`
- Leave `baseurl` empty



2. Commit the change.
3. Wait about 5 minutes. Al-folio automatically builds your site using GitHub Actions and pushes the result to a new branch called `gh-pages`.
4. Go to **Settings** → **Pages**.
- Change **Source** from **"GitHub Actions"** to **"Deploy from a branch."**
 - Select `gh-pages` as the branch and `/(root)` as the folder.
 - Click **Save**.

Why: al-folio builds your website automatically in the background and saves the finished version to a branch called `gh-pages`. This step tells GitHub to actually show that finished version to visitors.



5. Wait 1–2 minutes, then visit <https://yourusername.github.io>.

Your live website link: [Type here]

If your site shows a 404 or doesn't load, Ask Copilot for help.

Part 5: Add Your Bio, Photo, and CV

AI-folio has built-in support for a short bio, a profile photo, and a downloadable CV/resume. Let's set those up.

Your bio:

1. Open `_pages/about.md` in the GitHub web editor.

2. Replace the placeholder text with a short bio about yourself. a few sentences on who you are, what you're studying or working on, and what you're interested in.

Write your biography here. Tell the world about yourself. Link to your favorite [subreddit](#). You can put a picture in, too. The code is already in, just name your picture `prof_pic.jpg` and put it in the `img/` folder.

Put your address / P.O. box / other info right below your picture. You can also disable any of these elements by editing `profile` property of the YAML header of your `_pages/about.md`. Edit `_bibliography/papers.bib` and Jekyll will render your [publications page](#) automatically.

Link to your social media connections, too. This theme is set up to use [Font Awesome icons](#) and [Academicicons](#), like the ones below. Add your Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, Google Scholar, or just disable all of them.

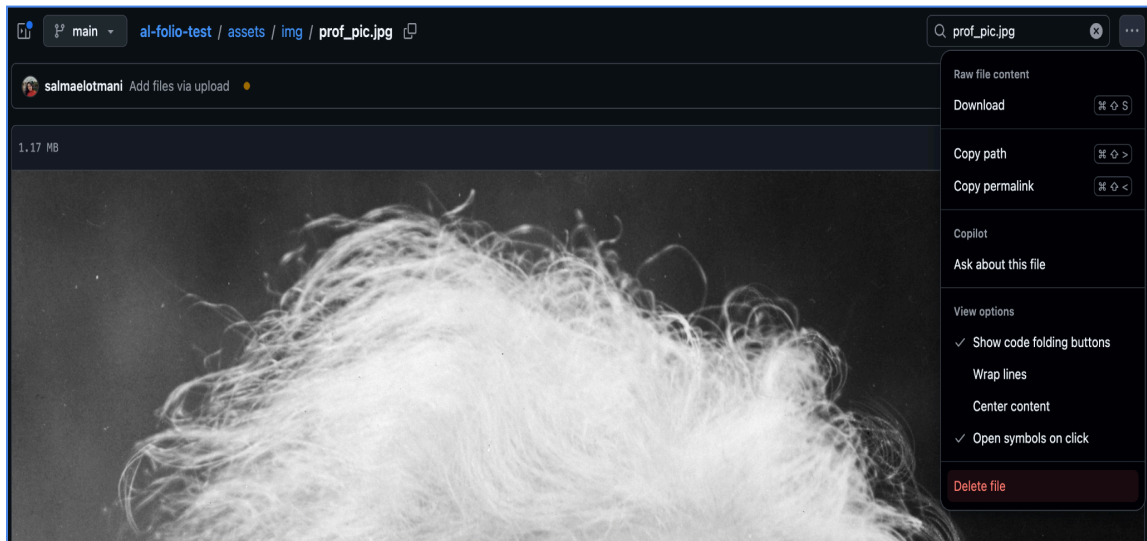
Your prompt(s) for drafting or revising your bio: [Type here]

Your photo:

1. Prepare a clear, professional photo of yourself, name it `prof_pic.jpg` (or `.png`).
2. In your repository, navigate to `assets/img/`.

Name	Last commit message
..	
book_covers	Initial commit
publication_preview	Initial commit
1.jpg	Initial commit
10.jpg	Initial commit
11.jpg	Initial commit

3. Delete current `prof_pic.jpg`.



4. Click **Add file** → **Upload files**, and upload your photo there, replacing the existing placeholder image if there is one.
5. Commit the change.

Your CV:

1. Save your resume or CV as a PDF. (Use the resume/CV from Activity 2)
2. In your repository, navigate to `assets/pdf/`.
3. Click **Add file** → **Upload files**, and upload your PDF. Name it `CV.pdf` (check `_config.yml` or ask Copilot to confirm the exact filename al-folio expects, since this can vary by version).
4. If your CV isn't showing a download link on your site, ask Copilot: "Where in this al-folio repo do I add a CV download link to my about page?"

What did you have to adjust or troubleshoot to get your CV linked correctly? [Type here]

Understanding your Actions checks

When you save a change, GitHub runs a bunch of automatic checks in the background. You'll often see a message like "Some checks were not successful," don't panic, this is normal and doesn't mean your site is broken. Here's what to actually pay attention to:

-  **Deploy site / deploy:** This is the only one that really matters. If this one has a checkmark, your website is live and working.
-  **Prettier code formatter / check:** This one fails a lot. It's just checking code style, not whether your site works. You can ignore it.
- The rest (CodeQL, Integration tests, Upgrade contract checks, link checker, star history) are background checks for the template itself, not content. You don't need to understand or fix them.

Some checks were not successful			×
1 failing, 2 skipped, and 5 successful checks			
✗	 Prettier code formatter / check (push)	Failing after 24s	Details
✓	 CodeQL Advanced / Analyze (javascript-typescript) (push)	Successful in 2m	Details
✓	 CodeQL Advanced / Analyze (ruby) (push)	Successful in 47s	Details
✓	 Integration tests / comments-integration-tests (push)	Successful in 3m	Details
✓	 Deploy site / deploy (push)	Successful in 1m	Details
⌚	 Check for broken links / link-checker (push)	Skipped	Details
⌚	 Update star history chart / update (push)	Skipped	Details
✓	 Upgrade contract checks / upgrade-check (push)	Successful in 33s	Details

Part 6: Add something new

Now go beyond the basics. Pick at least one thing to add, change, or build that wasn't part of the instructions above. For example, a blog post, a publication entry, a new project description, a change to the site's colors or layout, anything you're curious about.

What did you decide to add or change, and why? [Type here]

Your prompt(s) for this part:

- [Type here]

What happened? Did it work as expected, or did you need to troubleshoot? [Type here]

Part 7: Your Final Website

Your final live website link: [Type here]

Part 8: Reflection

Think about your experience working with AI on this activity.

1. What did you like and dislike about using AI for this activity?

[Type here]

2. Where did you rely on AI, and where did you rely on your own judgment?

[Type here]

3. Did anything surprise, confuse, or not work as you expected?

[Type here]

4. Would you use AI for a task like this again? Why or Why not?

[Type here]

5. What would you like to learn more about?

[Type here]